SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #21 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“Everyone else's life is better than mine.”

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Where it often comes from

Social media shows other people’s best moments: vacations, new homes, engagements, promotions, happy kids. We compare those highlights to our own full, ordinary days. The longer we scroll, the more our life seems lacking, and envy and discouragement grow.

What Scripture teaches

Solomon observed, “All labor and success spring from a man’s envy of his neighbor. This too is futile and a pursuit of the wind.” Proverbs says, “A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones.” Paul writes, “Each one should test his own work. Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone, and not in someone else,” and “Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another.” He also says, “I have learned to be content” in plenty and in need. Comparison steals contentment. Gratitude and honest self-examination restore it.

> *“Each one should test his own work. Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone, and not in someone else”* (Galatians 6:4).

Also see

> “A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones” (Proverbs 14:30).

> “I saw that all labor and success spring from a man’s envy of his neighbor. This too is futile and a pursuit of the wind” (Ecclesiastes 4:4).

> “Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another” (Galatians 5:26).

> “I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” (Philippians 4:12–13).

Common self-statements

- Everyone else is happier than I am.
- I am falling behind.
- My life is boring and small.
- They have it all together.
- I am missing out.
- What is wrong with my life?

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Comparing my whole life with others’ highlights.
- Mental filter: Focusing on what I lack.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing others’ lives are perfect and mine is not.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking blessings in my own life.

Challenging questions

- What am I actually seeing online, and what am I not seeing?

- How do I feel after scrolling?
- What good things do I have that do not show up in photos?
- What would I think of my life if I could not compare?
- What does Scripture say about envy and contentment?
- What limits on social media would help?

Truth summary

> Online lives are curated. My life has real struggles and real blessings, and God has given me my own path. I can limit comparison, give thanks, and invest in the life in front of me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Envy/Jealousy
- Thankful
- Dissatisfaction
- Joy
- Thinking, Healthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Everyone else's life is better than mine"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Everyone else's life is better than mine." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I not seeing online?
- ☐ How do I feel after scrolling?
- ☐ What am I thankful for?
- ☐ What limit would help?
- ☐ Who can I see in person?
- ☐ What is good in my life?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not see the whole picture online.
- ☐ Envy rots; a tranquil heart gives life.
- ☐ I can test my own work and not compare.
- ☐ Contentment can be learned.
- ☐ I have blessings I overlook.
- ☐ I can limit what feeds comparison.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 6:4**
  "Each one should test his own work. Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone, and not in someone else."
- ☐ **Proverbs 14:30**
  "A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones."
- ☐ **Philippians 4:12–13**
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Thankful instead of comparing: Each day, write three things you are thankful for in your own life.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 6:4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can test my own work and not compare myself to others.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Envy/Jealousy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Track how you feel. Note your mood before and after scrolling.
- [ ] Set limits. Reduce time or unfollow accounts that trigger comparison.
- [ ] Write a gratitude list. Name ten blessings that do not appear on screen.
- [ ] Reach out in person. Connect with a friend face to face.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Everyone else's life is better than mine": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Thankful, not comparing
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Everyone else's life is better than mine.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I compare my life to highlights and feel small. Teach me contentment, show me my own blessings, and help me live fully in the life You gave me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.